Inventory · Stack · Structure

checklist

Items with state markers — done, partial, failed, unknown, to do, skipped.

The checklist tracks readiness in six answers.

- Done rows take a solid check
- Half-done rows show the dash
- Failed rows take the red cross
- Unsettled rows ring a question mark
- Open rows stay an empty ring
- ~~Descoped rows get the slash~~

Nine rows is where the checklist overflows.

- [x] The first rows land while attention is fresh
- [x] Sixteen words is the budget a stress row may spend
- [x] Three checks in a row read as momentum
- [-] A dash admits the honest middle state
- [x] A red cross marks the check that failed
- [?] A ringed question admits what is unknown
- [ ] Late rows stay short; the audience is counting now
- [/] ~~The slash records what was cut, visibly~~
- [x] Nine is the last row this layout seats

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When NOT to reach for checklist.

All-done lists

If every item is `[x]` the state markers are decoration. Use `list` (or its `takeaway` variant) for celebratory recaps; checklist earns its weight when the mix matters.

Long per-item prose

Each item is one short line. If a row needs a sentence of explanation, the right home is cards-stack or list-tabular.

Custom state markers

Only the six markers — `[x]` `[-]` `[!]` `[?]` `[ ]` `[/]` — map to the mark palette. Anything else in brackets (`[X]`, `[~]`, `[>]`) renders as literal text and breaks the visual contract. `[X]` is the trap: GitHub-flavored markdown reads it as a checked box, and it does not draw a mark here.

Related components

See also.

`list` — items have no state — just bullets

`list-tabular` — rows need a label-plus-description structure, not state

`cards-stack` — each item needs two sentences of body